

Reuse Models Ponyup Reconnect Laptop Initiative

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Reuse-first models deep dive — PonyUp for Good, The Reconnect Project and The Laptop Initiative

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Purpose: understand three Australian models that capture whole-device value before recycling, and identify what is transferable to Dubbo eWaste.

Executive summary

These organisations are all "reuse first", but they solve very different problems.

Model | Primary customer/source | What it accepts | Core value | Revenue/funding | What happens to failures

PonyUp for Good | businesses disposing of decommissioned IT | broad corporate IT; strongest reuse focus on roughly 2–5-year-old assets | secure ITAD + resale + ESG/social impact | collection/service fees + resale; 50% of profits to SecondBite | ANZRP / accredited recycling partners

The Reconnect Project | public, businesses, government, social-service network | phones/tablets any age/condition; laptops <8 years | repair/refurbishment + affordable resale/donation + employment/training | repairs + refurbished sales + grants/donations/contracts | parts harvesting, then Australian reproprocessors

The Laptop Initiative | corporate laptop donors | already-good laptops, usually ≤4 years old | direct redistribution to charities with minimal storage/repair overhead | charity donations/sponsorship; devices gifted, not sold | largely avoided at intake; organisation says it does not repair gifted laptops

The most transferable model for Dubbo eWaste is not one organisation by itself:

PonyUp's business-client asset-control + Reconnect's repair/parts triage + The Laptop Initiative's strict acceptance criteria and fast onward movement.

1. PonyUp for Good

1.1 What it is

PonyUp for Good Pty Ltd (ABN 89 610 863 717) is an Australian private company established in 2016 and operates as a certified social enterprise.

It is aimed primarily at businesses with decommissioned technology, not small household drop-offs.

PonyUp describes itself as:

- a social enterprise;
- an ESG engagement agency;
- an IT asset-disposition/reuse service;

- a "reuse first" operation.

It converts unwanted corporate technology into:

1. reusable second-hand equipment;
2. auditable ESG outcomes;
3. residual recycling;
4. charitable funding.

PonyUp says 50% of its profits are donated to food-rescue charity SecondBite.

1.2 Intake model

PonyUp's strongest reuse candidates are decommissioned corporate devices around 2-5 years old.

Its own reuse guide lists:

- laptops and tablets;
- desktops;
- servers;
- switches;
- routers/network equipment;
- monitors 24 inches and above;
- mobile phones.

It can accept broader corporate e-waste for recycling even where reuse is not viable.

PonyUp specifically tells individuals that its service is primarily for bulk business technology; small household quantities are directed toward TechCollect.

Important commercial lesson

PonyUp does not present itself as "bring us any electronics and we'll see what happens".

It deliberately targets higher-quality fleet refreshes, where:

- device provenance is clear;
- specifications are relatively consistent;
- equipment is recent enough to have resale value;
- quantities justify collection/logistics;
- a corporate client values reporting and risk control.

That is exactly the sort of supply Dubbo eWaste should prioritise.

1.3 Workflow

The published workflow is approximately:

business decommissions equipment

- PonyUp arranges collection/removal
- asset register / serial tracking
- secure data sanitisation
- debadging
- functional/condition assessment
- viable devices refurbished
- second-hand equipment remarketed
- non-reusable equipment sent to accredited recycling
- client receives outcome/ESG reporting
- 50% of PonyUp profits go to SecondBite.

"Plug-back" removal

PonyUp offers full office-move and upgrade services where it removes technology from the "plug back", clears sites and can warehouse equipment temporarily.

This means it wins supply at the moment a business upgrades, before equipment sits forgotten in storage or is called "waste".

That timing is commercially important because PonyUp says technology depreciates quickly if left in storage.

1.4 Data security

This is one of PonyUp's strongest differentiators.

PonyUp says its partners use:

- Blancco erasure systems;
- Aiken/Aitken Workbench sanitisation;
- certificates of data destruction/erasure;
- serial-number asset registers;
- client-specific security profiles.

Its published material says unsuccessful sanitisation results in physical destruction/recycling.

It specifically argues against businesses automatically removing and shredding every hard drive because that can destroy otherwise reusable computers.

Lesson for Dubbo

A serious business-facing reuse operation needs to sell trust, not just "I can fix computers".

The business-client offer should eventually be something like:

asset list + serial number → secure erase result → reuse/recycle outcome → final report

That is much more valuable to organisations than a generic free e-waste pickup.

1.5 Refurbishment and resale

PonyUp explicitly says:

- it cleans/debadges equipment;
- data is erased;
- reusable assets are refurbished;
- the technology is remarketed as second-hand equipment.

This is a commercial resale model, not a donation-only charity model.

PonyUp says reuse can extend equipment life by up to seven years.

It also reports the percentage of devices reused versus recycled to clients.

Public impact figures

PonyUp's current published impact material says it has achieved roughly:

- 600,000+ kg of technology diverted from landfill;
- approximately 32–32.5% of collected equipment reused;
- 1 million+ meals funded via SecondBite.

These are company-reported figures, not independently audited figures found in this research.

ANZRP's 2024–25 annual report independently confirms the operational relationship:

- PonyUp collects technology;
- erases data;
- debadges;
- refurbishes;
- remarkets viable products;
- ANZRP recycles technology that cannot be reused.

ANZRP reported that its logistics/recycling support for PonyUp client collections had helped enable 55,363 meals and kept 107,137 kg of technology out of landfill through that partnership to the report date.

1.6 Downstream recycling

PonyUp identifies ANZRP as its accredited recycling partner for equipment with no reuse potential.

PonyUp says its recycling chain uses partners meeting:

- NTCRS requirements;
- AS/NZS 5377;
- relevant ISO environmental/security standards.

This is the cleanest "reuse first → regulated recycling second" structure found in the research.

1.7 Economics

PonyUp is not simply funded by selling old laptops.

Its value proposition includes:

- paid collection/logistics;
- data destruction;
- asset registers;
- office-clearing/project services;
- ESG reporting;
- carbon/emissions reporting;
- resale value;
- corporate engagement/communications.

This is important.

Lesson

For Dubbo eWaste, the long-term business model may be more durable if it earns money from:

service + resale, not resale alone.

Possible future paid services:

- collection;
- inventory;
- data sanitisation;
- certificate/report generation;
- fleet clear-out;
- pickup/project fee;
- downstream recycling coordination.

2. The Reconnect Project

2.1 What it is

The Reconnect Project Limited (ABN 50 634 550 388) is a NSW charity and social enterprise based in Penshurst.

It combines:

- a public repair shop;
- technology donation;
- refurbishment;
- affordable resale;
- charitable device distribution;

- parts harvesting;
- neurodivergent employment/training;
- government/business asset decommissioning.

The NSW Government's buy.nsw supplier profile says government agencies use Reconnect for:

- decommissioning mobile phones, tablets and laptops;
- collection;
- secure data erasure;
- asset-disposition reporting.

This is a much broader operating model than a simple donation charity.

2.2 Intake criteria

Reconnect is far more permissive than PonyUp or The Laptop Initiative.

Current published donation criteria:

- mobile phones: all makes/models, any age/condition;
- tablets: all makes/models, any age/condition;
- laptops: generally less than 8 years old.

It accepts:

- individual donations;
- drop-offs;
- mail-ins;
- corporate/bulk donations (more than 10 devices triggers a bulk enquiry).

This broad intake works because Reconnect has an actual repair workshop and can:

- repair;
- refurbish;
- harvest parts;
- retail;
- donate;
- recycle.

2.3 Actual triage workflow

Reconnect describes a clear device-level workflow:

device donated

- volunteer assesses functionality
- identify required spare parts
- technician repairs/refurbishes
- secure erase using Blancco

- device either sold affordably or allocated through support agencies
- unrepairable devices become donor parts
- unusable residual parts/devices go to Australian-based reprocessors.

This is one of the clearest real-world examples of the hierarchy:

whole-device reuse → repair → parts harvesting → material recycling

rather than jumping from "unwanted" directly to shredder.

Data

Reconnect says:

- donors should factory-reset/remove Apple/Google account information where possible;
- Reconnect can perform secure erase using Blancco;
- a Certificate of Erasure can be provided;
- it asks for about \$5 per device to help cover certificate cost.

That is a useful example of charging a small fee for traceable sanitisation without making the service prohibitively expensive.

2.4 Refurbishment economics

Reconnect states that the average cost to restore a device is around \$200 on its current donation page.

A supporting foundation page previously reported approximate costs of:

- about \$100 to refurbish a phone;
- about \$300 to refurbish a laptop.

These figures may refer to different periods/categories and should not be treated as a single current cost schedule.

Reconnect funds its operation through a mixed model:

- public repair services;
- sales of refurbished devices;
- donations;
- grants;
- government/business work;
- social-enterprise activity.

Current retail operation

Reconnect has a real online shop selling professionally refurbished technology, including:

- phones;
- laptops;
- accessories;

- other electronics.

Current listings demonstrate that it is not merely distributing every repaired device for free.

Some repaired stock is sold, and proceeds support the wider mission.

This is strategically useful for Dubbo eWaste because it demonstrates:

social impact and resale revenue can coexist.

2.5 Distribution model

Reconnect also sends refurbished phones, tablets and laptops to people in need through partner agencies, rather than handling individual direct applications.

Current partner categories include:

- women's refuges;
- homelessness agencies;
- refugee/asylum-seeker support;
- youth outreach;
- other social-service organisations.

Its current distribution page reports 4,800+ devices distributed.

The website says social-service organisations and registered charities can join its Partner Agency program; individuals cannot directly register themselves for a device.

Why that matters

Using caseworkers/partner agencies:

- verifies genuine need;
- reduces administrative burden;
- lets specialists decide who most needs what type of device;
- avoids turning the refurbisher into a welfare eligibility agency.

This is a strong design pattern if Dubbo eWaste ever wants a donation stream.

2.6 Employment and training model

Reconnect is unusual because the repair operation is also a workforce-development program.

It trains/employs neurodivergent young adults in:

- device repair;
- retail;
- customer service;
- workplace communication.

Government and foundation sources describe the workshop as a real commercial environment, not a simulated training lab.

The organisation's repair fees and refurbished sales therefore support:

1. circular-economy outcomes;
2. digital inclusion;
3. employment/training.

Dubbo lesson

Do not copy this component at Phase 0.

It adds:

- employment obligations;
- supervision;
- training design;
- workshop capacity;
- insurance;
- payroll;
- social-service governance.

But it is a possible long-term model if Dubbo eWaste grows enough to support trainees/apprentice-style roles.

2.7 Repair scope

Reconnect's public repair shop goes well beyond phones:

- phones;
- tablets/iPads;
- laptops;
- gaming consoles;
- smart watches;
- MP3 players;
- vintage radios;
- lamps;
- small appliances.

That breadth creates more repair revenue but also requires:

- specialised skills;
- parts sourcing;
- tools;
- diagnosis time;
- warranty/consumer-law processes.

For Dubbo Phase 0, narrower is safer.

2.8 Downstream failures

Reconnect says:

- unrepaired devices are first retained for useful spare parts;
- broken parts/devices that cannot be revived go to Australian-based reproprocessors;
- phones sent for final recycling are shredded and valuable metals recovered.

It does not publicly name the exact current reproprocessor on the donation page examined.

That is a downstream question worth asking if using Reconnect as a benchmark.

3. The Laptop Initiative

3.1 What it is

The Laptop Initiative Limited (ABN 95 671 869 364) is an ACNC-registered charity and Public Benevolent Institution.

It was founded in 2024 and is still comparatively small and volunteer-led.

Its model is intentionally simple:

business has good, recently retired laptop

- business wipes/prepares it
- The Laptop Initiative matches it to a charity need
- laptop is delivered quickly
- charity gives it to the end user.

All donated devices are gifted, not sold.

In September 2026, The Laptop Initiative announced a milestone of 1,000 laptops.

3.2 Very strict acceptance criteria

This model only works because intake is narrow.

Published criteria generally require:

- laptop around 4 years old or newer;
- high-end models may be slightly older;
- good condition;
- webcam;
- charger;
- sanitised/wiped;
- current/updated Windows installation;

- working device.

The organisation explicitly says:

it does not repair laptops after they are gifted.

So unlike Reconnect, The Laptop Initiative is not trying to rescue broken hardware.

Key design principle

Reject repair liability upstream.

The business donor is expected to provide equipment that is essentially deployment-ready.

This keeps the charity:

- low overhead;
- low storage;
- low parts cost;
- low workshop complexity;
- focused on matching and logistics.

3.3 Data sanitisation

Corporate donors normally prepare/wipe devices themselves.

If they cannot:

- The Laptop Initiative has trusted data-wiping partners;
- secure pickup/transport can be arranged;
- certified wiping can be purchased.

The current website is internally inconsistent about the named partner:

- one current signup page names Renew IT;
- some older/current cached FAQ sections name Zolo.

Do not assume one provider is the exclusive current partner without asking The Laptop Initiative.

The stable fact is:

- third-party professional data wiping is available;
- the service can operate nationally;
- the corporate donor pays for it.

3.4 Almost no warehousing

This is one of the smartest parts of the model.

The Laptop Initiative says that when it knows a corporate donation is coming, it contacts charity partners to determine:

- who needs devices;
- how many;
- where;
- which need is most urgent.

It then attempts to pick up and deliver the laptops within a few days.

Its stated objective is to avoid:

- warehouses;
- long-term storage;
- devices depreciating while sitting idle.

Dubbo lesson

This principle is extremely transferable:

find the outlet before accepting the stock.

For a small home-based operation, that is much safer than accumulating piles of "maybe useful one day" equipment.

3.5 Distribution

The Laptop Initiative does not generally hand laptops directly to individuals.

It distributes through charity partners serving:

- refugees and asylum seekers;
- disadvantaged young people;
- women escaping domestic violence;
- other people experiencing disadvantage.

Examples currently shown include:

- women's support organisations;
- youth/education charities;
- community organisations.

The charity partners perform the final recipient selection.

3.6 Funding model

Unlike PonyUp:

- laptops are not resold;
- there is no resale profit to fund operations.

Unlike Reconnect:

- there is no major public repair-shop revenue stream.

Costs are supported by:

- financial donations;
- sponsors;
- volunteer labour;
- corporate donors preparing their own devices;
- external partners for specialised wiping/logistics.

The Laptop Initiative says logistics are one of its biggest costs.

This is crucial for a regional Australian model.

A laptop may be "free", but:

- pickup;
- freight;
- packaging;
- missing chargers;
- prep;
- wiping;
- Windows setup;
- delivery

all cost money/time.

4. Direct comparison

4.1 Device age / quality threshold

PonyUp

Best reuse target:

- roughly 2–5 years old;
- corporate grade;
- good resale potential.

Reconnect

Much more tolerant:

- phones/tablets: any age/condition;
- laptops: <8 years;
- repair/parts capability makes this possible.

Laptop Initiative

Most selective:

- normally ≤ 4 years;
- already good/working;

- charger/webcam;
- sanitised and prepared.

Dubbo implication

For Phase 0, a threshold closer to PonyUp + Laptop Initiative is safer than Reconnect.

4.2 Who does the work?

PonyUp

Professional operations/service partners:

- logistics;
- data sanitisation;
- refurbishment;
- wholesale remarketing;
- recycling.

Reconnect

In-house/volunteer/paid workshop:

- diagnosis;
- repair;
- parts harvesting;
- sanitisation;
- retail;
- training.

Laptop Initiative

Most preparation happens before or around intake:

- donor IT teams;
- professional wiping partner if needed;
- volunteer coordination;
- charity distribution.

Dubbo implication

Start with:

- owner-operated testing/repair;
- no employees;
- no public welfare eligibility process;
- no attempt to repair everything.

4.3 Revenue and value capture

PonyUp

Captures commercial value:

- service fees;
- resale;
- ESG reporting;
- carbon reporting;
- corporate project work.

Reconnect

Mixed:

- retail repairs;
- refurbished device sales;
- grants/donations;
- government/business services.

Laptop Initiative

No resale:

- charitable giving;
- sponsorship;
- donor-funded prep/logistics.

Dubbo implication

The strongest business case is closer to PonyUp:

- resale value funds the operation.

A later donation stream could copy Reconnect/Laptop Initiative without making every good device a donation.

4.4 What happens when reuse fails?

PonyUp

ANZRP/accredited recycler.

Reconnect

Harvest useful parts first, then Australian reproprocessors.

Laptop Initiative

Avoids most failures through strict intake; exact failure path is not prominent in current public material.

Dubbo implication

The ideal hierarchy is:

1. resale/redeploy whole;
2. economical repair;

3. donation if commercially appropriate;
4. useful donor parts;
5. verified recycling;
6. avoid accepting items with no known route.

5. What Dubbo eWaste should copy now

From PonyUp

- business-first sourcing;
- target fleet refreshes;
- reuse percentage reporting;
- serial-number asset records;
- documented data sanitisation;
- resell viable devices;
- recycle only failures;
- offer collection as a service;
- eventually report environmental outcomes.

From Reconnect

- actual functional triage before declaring something waste;
- repair before dismantling;
- harvest donor parts;
- combine paid repair/resale with social outcomes;
- use partner agencies if donating devices;
- refuse to waste repairable equipment simply because it was "donated as e-waste".

From The Laptop Initiative

- tight acceptance criteria;
- equipment must have a known destination;
- move stock quickly;
- keep warehousing minimal;
- use external specialist wiping where needed;
- let existing charities determine social need rather than administering that yourself.

6. What Dubbo eWaste should NOT copy at Phase 0

Do not initially copy:

- PonyUp's national enterprise logistics;
- carbon accounting;
- large corporate security programs;

- Reconnect's broad "any age/condition" phone intake;
- Reconnect's employment/training operation;
- Reconnect's very broad repair scope;
- The Laptop Initiative's donation-only economics;
- national freight/distribution.

Those models developed organisational capacity around those functions.

Phase 0 should remain:

small → selective → high-resale-probability → documented → quick-turn → known downstream route

7. A hybrid model for Dubbo

A practical future operating model could be:

Stream A — commercial reuse

local business/school/farm replaces equipment

- Dubbo eWaste inventories it
- ownership transferred
- secure sanitisation
- test/grade
- refurbish
- resell locally/online
- client receives outcome report.

This is the PonyUp component.

Stream B — social reuse

Some devices that are useful but not worth commercial selling:

- clean/test/setup
- pass through a local charity/community partner
- partner selects recipient.

This is the Reconnect / Laptop Initiative component.

Stream C — donor parts

Repair failures:

- harvest RAM/SSD/screens/chargers/boards/components where lawful and worthwhile
- repair other devices.

This is the Reconnect component.

Stream D — true end-of-life

Zero-value remainder:

- batteries separated appropriately
- verified downstream recycler such as AMR/NTCRS route depending category
- retain recycling receipt/weight where possible.

This is the ANZRP/TechCollect component.

8. Possible business-client pitch derived from these models

The commercially meaningful offer is not:

"Give me your e-waste."

It is:

"Before you recycle your old IT, let us determine what still has value. We inventory and securely erase your equipment, refurbish and reuse what is viable, recover useful parts where appropriate, and send only genuine end-of-life material to recycling."

That distinguishes Dubbo eWaste from a scrap yard or ordinary collection cage.

9. Questions worth asking each organisation

PonyUp

- What minimum volume makes a regional collection viable?
- What percentage of equipment is currently reused?
- What age/spec thresholds determine resale?
- Who legally owns the equipment after collection?
- How are resale proceeds split/accounted?
- Which refurb/wholesale resale channels are used?
- What does a small regional business need to become a feeder/partner?
- Would PonyUp accept sorted viable corporate equipment originating in Dubbo?
- Could Dubbo eWaste act as a regional collection/triage partner?
- What parts of their operation are performed directly versus by service partners?

Reconnect

- What percentage of donated devices are refurbished whole, harvested for parts and recycled?
- What faults make repair uneconomic?
- What is the typical repair cost/labour per laptop/phone?
- Which Australian reprocessors receive the unrepairable remainder?
- How do they grade devices for affordable resale versus charitable distribution?

- How are donated devices valued/accounted for?
- Could a regional refurbisher supply repaired devices or donor parts?
- Could Dubbo organisations ship bulk phones/tablets/laptops to Penshurst?
- How do they handle batteries and locked/activation-locked devices?

The Laptop Initiative

- Exact 2026 minimum specification and Windows requirements.
- Is ≤ 4 years a hard rule or a guideline?
- Which data-wiping partner is current: Renew IT, Zolo, or both?
- What happens to a laptop discovered faulty after intake?
- Who pays freight from regional NSW?
- Could a Dubbo refurbisher prepare devices to the required standard then donate them?
- Is there demand through charity partners in Western NSW?
- Could Dubbo eWaste act as a regional preparation/logistics partner?
- What documentation is required from corporate donors?

10. Sources

PonyUp for Good

- Main site / reuse-first model: <https://www.ponyupforgood.com/>
- Services / asset register / certificates / recycling: <https://www.ponyupforgood.com/our-services>
- FAQ / 2-5 year target / data handling / reuse-v-recycle reporting: <https://www.ponyupforgood.com/faq>
- Data security / Blancco / ANZRP: <https://www.ponyupforgood.com/partners-data-security>
- Donate devices / accepted reusable corporate categories: <https://www.ponyupforgood.com/donate-devices>
- ESG reporting: <https://www.ponyupforgood.com/esg-reporting>
- Impact figures: <https://www.ponyupforgood.com/1-million-meals>
- ABR: <https://abr.business.gov.au/ABN/View?abn=89610863717>
- Social Traders case study / independent description of operating model: <https://www.socialtraders.com.au/news/ponyup-for-good-nandos-partnership>
- ANZRP partnership: <https://www.anzrp.com.au/partnerships/ponyup-for-good/>
- ANZRP 2024-25 annual report: https://www.anzrp.com.au/wp-content/uploads/2025/11/29632-anzrp-annual-report-2024-25_regulator_web_final.pdf

The Reconnect Project

- Main site: <https://thereconnectproject.com.au/>
- Donate / exact triage and acceptance criteria: <https://thereconnectproject.com.au/donate/>
- Distribute / partner-agency model and current device count: <https://thereconnectproject.com.au/distribute/>
- Repair / repair scope and refurbished retail: <https://thereconnectproject.com.au/repair/>
- Shop: <https://thereconnectproject.com.au/shop/>
- FAQ: <https://thereconnectproject.com.au/faq/>
- Training: <https://thereconnectproject.com.au/training/>
- About: <https://thereconnectproject.com.au/about-us/>

- NSW Government supplier profile: <https://buy.nsw.gov.au/supplier/profile/136694>
- ANZRP partnership: <https://www.anzrp.com.au/partnerships/the-reconnect-project/>
- Banksia Foundation 2024 national circular-economy award: <https://banksiafdn.com/national-winners-2024/>
- NSW Small Business Commissioner profile: <https://www.smallbusiness.nsw.gov.au/news-podcasts/news/annett-e-brodie-how-a-tech-repair-shop-is-making-a-difference-in-sydney>

The Laptop Initiative

- Main site: <https://thelaptopinitiative.com.au/>
- About / criteria / direct-distribution model: <https://thelaptopinitiative.com.au/about/>
- Corporate Hero process: <https://thelaptopinitiative.com.au/corporate-hero/>
- Partners and charities: <https://thelaptopinitiative.com.au/partners-and-charities/>
- Donation/signup criteria and current Renew IT reference:
<https://thelaptopinitiative.com.au/become-a-hero-signup/>
- Current news / 1,000-laptop milestone: <https://thelaptopinitiative.com.au/latest-news/>
- ABR / charity registration: <https://abr.business.gov.au/ABN/View?abn=95671869364>
- ANZRP partnership: <https://www.anzrp.com.au/partnerships/the-laptop-initiative/>

11. Bottom line

The most important lesson from all three is:

Do not wait until a device is labelled "e-waste" to decide whether it has reuse value.

PonyUp captures the commercial value before recycling.

Reconnect captures repair and parts value before recycling.

The Laptop Initiative captures social-use value before recycling.

A strong Dubbo model can combine all three, while using a recycler only for what is truly end-of-life.